

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

The concept of sustainable development

Humanity has the ability to make development sustainable to ensure that it meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. The concept of sustainable development does imply limits - not absolute limits but limitations imposed by the present state of technology and social organization on environmental resources and by the ability of the biosphere to absorb the effects of human activities. But technology and social organization can be both managed and improved to make way for a new era of economic growth. The Commission believes that widespread poverty is no longer inevitable. Poverty is not only an evil in itself, but sustainable development requires meeting the basic needs of all and extending to all the opportunities to fulfil their aspirations for a better life. A world in which poverty is endemic will always be prone to ecological and other catastrophes.

Meeting essential needs requires not only a new era of economic growth for nations in which the majority are poor but an assurance that those poor get their fair share of the resources required to sustain that growth. Such equity would be aided by political systems that secure effective citizen participation in decision-making and by greater democracy in international decision-making.

Sustainable global development requires that those who are more affluent adopt lifestyles within the planet's ecological means - in their use of energy, for example. Further, rapidly growing populations can increase the pressure on resources and slow any rise in living standards; thus sustainable development can only be pursued if population size and growth are in harmony with the changing productive potential of the ecosystem.

Yet in the end, sustainable development is not a fixed state of harmony, but rather a process of change in which the exploitation of resources, the direction of investments, the orientation of technological development, and institutional change are made consistent with the future as well as present needs. We do not pretend that the process is easy or straightforward. Painful choices have to be made.

The genesis of sustainable development goals

World Summit on Sustainable Development which was held in Johannesburg renewed international commitment to the pursuit of sustainable development with the Johannesburg Plan of Implementation (JPOI); 2012 resulted in an outcome document "The Future We Want". In the document, the States reaffirmed the commitments to all previous sustainable development agreements, plans and targets. They also committed to developing a suite of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) building on the priorities identified in Agenda 21 and the JPOI, and decided to replace the Commission for Sustainable Development with a 'high-level political forum' to progress implementation of Agenda 21 and the JPOI, and the achievement of the SDGs. The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) were agreed upon at the United Nations in New York in September 2015.

Sustainable Development Goals are

Goal 1: End poverty in all its forms everywhere

Goal 2: End hunger, achieve food security and improved nutrition and promote sustainable agriculture;

Goal 3: Ensure healthy lives and promote well-being for all at all ages;

Goal 4: Ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all;

Goal 5: Achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls;

Goal 6: Ensure availability and sustainable management of water and sanitation for all;

Goal 7: Ensure access to affordable, reliable, sustainable and modern energy for all;

Goal 8: Promote sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth, full and productive employment and decent work for all;

Goal 9: Build resilient infrastructure, promote inclusive and sustainable industrialization and foster innovation;

Goal 10: Reduce inequality within and among countries;

Goal 11: Make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable;

Goal 12: Ensure sustainable consumption and production patterns;

Goal 13: Take urgent action to combat climate change and its impacts;

Goal 14: Conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development;

Goal 15: Protect, restore and promote sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, sustainably manage forests, combat desertification, and halt and reverse land degradation and halt biodiversity loss;

Goal 16: Promote peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, provide access to justice for all and build effective, accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels; and

Goal 17: Strengthen the means of implementation and revitalize the global partnership for sustainable development.

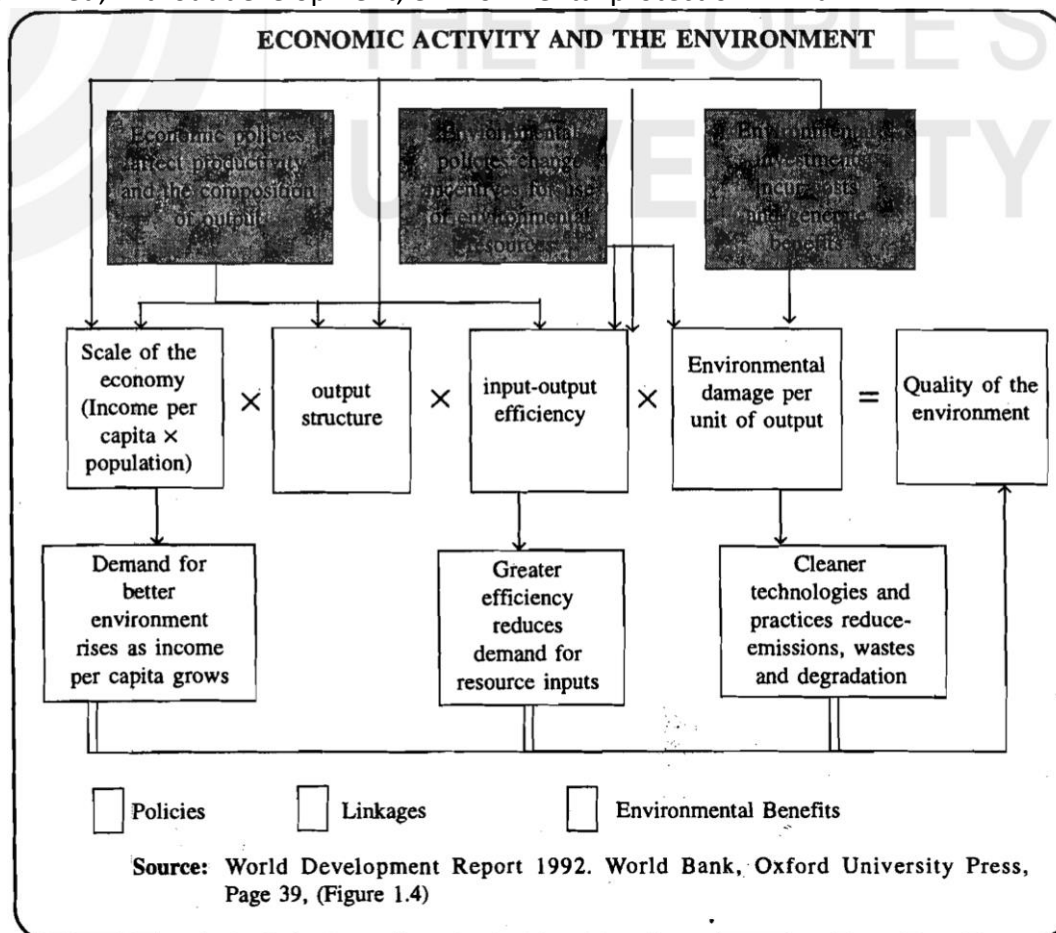


SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS
17 GOALS TO TRANSFORM OUR WORLD



Sustainable human development and the environment

Economic development and sound environmental management are complementary aspects of the same agenda. Without adequate environmental protection, development will be undermined; without development, environmental protection will fail.



Awareness

Environmental conservation and regeneration are emerging concerns for one and all. These should not be seen as someone else's responsibility. The results are the consequence for all of us across all age groups and social strata.

The nation today needs a well-developed policy on the environment. This would mean awareness at the nationwide level. This would also mean well-planned action. For this, it is necessary to understand the causes of ignorance about the environment and the misconceptions about it.

In India, ignorance and misconceptions prevail because of illiteracy on a large scale, lack of proper orientation and training of functionaries and leaders, and lack of organised effort on the part of the educational system to address these problems systematically.

Environmental matters of vital concern relate to the areas of agriculture, industry and health. Knowledge about these and other areas can be imparted to the concerned people through various educational programmes such as formal education at school and college levels, non-formal education at the adult level, and special orientation and training of the functionaries

and opinion leaders. Mass media can play a vital role in this matter. It should be the concern of the recipient to seek this knowledge rather than wait to be exposed to it.